According to archeologists, the Mon were the first identifiable ethnic group to migrate into what is now Myanmar. Relatively little is known about the origin of the Mon, but it is thought that the Mon began migrating from the Yangtze River valley in southern China to the Upper Mekong as early as 3000 BCE, eventually settling between the Salween and Sittang Rivers in the Ayeyarwaddy River delta and along the Taninthayi coast in Lower Myanmar sometime between 2500 BCE and 1500 BCE. By mid-ninth century BCE, the Mon had come to dominate Lower Myanmar.

According to oral tradition as well as the Indian, Mon, and Burmese chronicles, the first Mon kingdom in Myanmar was founded by King Siharaja during the Buddha's lifetime and was called Suwarnabhumi or “land of gold” and later known as Ramannadesa or “land of Ramanna” located in the lower Ayeyarwaddy River delta near the port of Thaton. Over time the Mon slowly extended their sphere of influence from Cape Negaris in the Ayeyarwaddy delta up to the Chao Phraya delta and into modern Thailand, reaching as far as present-day Laos but were stopped when they encountered the Khmer kingdom at Angkor. There is evidence that the Mon kingdom at Thaton had contact and engaged in trade with both India and Sri Lanka.

Suwarnabhumi is connected with the historical Buddha in later Mon and Burmese chronicles that credit the Mon as the first to establish Buddhism in Myanmar. The Indian, Mon, and Burmese chronicles suggest that the Mon had contact with Buddhism in the third century BCE as Mauryan king Asoká (r. ca. 273–232) is known to have sent a mission of Śrāvakayāna Buddhist monks to Suwarnabhumi where they introduced Therāvāda Buddhism to the Mon. Later Burmese chronicles suggest that Buddhist manuscripts from Sri Lanka were translated into Mon characters around 400 CE. Monasteries, stupas, and inscriptions link the Mon in Lower Myanmar with the larger Buddhist community in Southeast Asia.

It appears that from 250 CE to 550 CE the Mon came under nominal control of Funan as the *Liang Shu* (the Annals of the Liang Dynasty) relate how the ruler of Funan utilized Mon troops to attack and conquer neighboring kingdoms. Free of Funanese subjugation, the Mon would go on to found the Dvāravatī Empire, which would last for over 500 years. Major Dvāravatī cities were located at Nakhon Pathom and U-Thong on the plains of Chao Phraya River valley. In 573 CE, the Mon established the kingdom of